

14 COMMUNICATION – ITS MEANS AND FORMS



Good communication is as stimulating as black coffee, and just as hard to sleep after.

Anne Morrow Lindbergh

If I am to speak ten minutes, I need a week for preparation; if fifteen minutes, three days; if half an hour, two days; if an hour, I am ready now.

Woodrow Wilson

□ VOCABULARY INPUT

Dealing with this topic you will come across the following vocabulary. Read it and look up the unknown words in your dictionary.

- **communication:** information exchange (encoding/decoding a message), communication intention, participants: senders, receivers, listener, speaker, interviewer, interviewee
- **types of communication:** *direct communication* (face to face communication)/*indirect communication*
- **forms of communication:**
 - oral communication:* (interaction in real time, negotiation of the meaning of messages, direct feedback, pauses, fillers, hesitation words, intonation)
 - written communication:* (precise choice of words and grammar, spelling, coherence, consistency of ideas)
- **non-verbal communication:**
 - body language, facial expressions, eye contact, mime, gestures, the movements of our hands, touches, proximity, body posture and overall appearance
- **formality of the discourse** (controlled use of language)/*informality* (slang, jargon, swear words, accent, colloquial expressions)
- **communication skills:** professional training, control of body language
- **historical development of communication:** through sounds, facial expressions, body posture, pictures, signs, letters
- **mass communication:** inventions, rapid spreading of information, storing and searching for information, socialising is weakened and threatened
- **other ways of communication:** Braille (the blind/visually impaired), sign language (the deaf), Morse Code, SOS (Save Our Souls)

□ DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Before reading the text, discuss the following questions in class.

1. How do people communicate?
2. How do animals and plants communicate?
3. How do people communicate with animals and vice versa?
4. Are there any animals that you think are capable of learning human language? Why?

5. What do you think is the difference between body language and sign language?
6. How would you express "I am angry" using body language?
7. Which jobs require good communication skills?
8. Which do you prefer? Talking to your friends face to face, on the phone or by Skype?
9. What kind of language do you use when you talk to your friends? Do you ever use slang or jargon?
10. How do you think people will communicate in the future?

□ TEXT

Read the texts below in silence. Check the meaning of the words in bold and answer the questions below.

WHAT IS COMMUNICATION?

Communication is the act of **exchanging thoughts**, ideas, messages or information between **senders** and **receivers** via some medium. Speakers send a message to their listeners who **encode** its meaning and then react to it. Daily, we send and **receive** new pieces of information when we talk to somebody, ask questions, write emails or text messages, explain rules, give instructions, **persuade** our friends to go out with us, **apologise** for misunderstandings, **complain** about bad service and so on. We communicate when we talk, listen, read, write, send signals or even look at somebody or something with interest. **Unless** there is a **purpose** (communication **intention**) for communication, it does not happen.

Nowadays, almost all professions **require** excellent **communication skills**. Many companies **provide** their employees with special communication training to **enhance** their employees' negotiation skills in order to deal with clients effectively. Communication courses train their participants on how to give clear messages, listen to each other, control the speed of their speech, use their voices and body language, **predict** information and **adjust** to different communication partners. Efficient communication skills are the main **prerequisite** to success in business, study and in our personal lives.

1. When do people communicate?
2. What do you understand by "communication skills"? Why are they important in our lives?

WRITTEN AND ORAL FORMS OF COMMUNICATION

There are two forms of communication: written and oral. The written form of communication requires a **precise** choice of words, correct grammar and a specific writing style. Written information has **permanent value** and can be read more times. **Visually-impaired** people and the blind can read **Braille** and use special reading machines which convert written text into speech or Braille. Speaking is more or less a **subconscious** process and does not require as much concentration as the written form does. Speakers and listeners **interact** in real time. Real-time communication **enables** listeners to ask for infor-

mation to be repeated which was not heard or understood. Since the message is expected to be given immediately without much thinking, speech often **contains** many pauses and **fillers** (*actually, well, you know what I mean, right...*). However, their **overuse** can be very **disturbing** for listeners. Intonation of the voice often **varies** according to the emotions of the speakers. In the oral form, the explanations of messages can also be **accompanied by non-verbal** communication. Our **facial expressions, mime, eye contact, gestures, touches, proximity, body posture** and overall **appearance** talk for us. They show our feelings and **reveal** our **current mood**. The main role of non-verbal communication is to keep the interest of listeners and **support** explanations. Non-verbal communication is very specific in different cultures. Politicians, diplomats and business managers practise different social behaviour **in accordance with** the rules written in *Diplomatic Protocol*. **The deaf** communicate just **via sign language** which combines the movement of the hands, arms and the body as well as facial expressions. They fully **rely on** their body language which enables them to express their thoughts.

3. What are the features of the written and oral forms of communication mentioned in the text above?
4. What are pros and cons of real time communication?
5. Which other means of communication can be used besides words?

TYPES OF COMMUNICATION

Communication happens in real time when **participants communicate face to face**. Such communication, also called **direct** communication, gives its participants the opportunity to **clarify** unheard or misunderstood messages either verbally or non-verbally. Communication can also be realised **indirectly** through various **communication channels** (telephones, contracts, letters, songs, posters, pictures) where senders and receivers of information do not see each other and do not necessarily know each other.

The choice of words, grammar and style of communication depends on **formality** and the importance of a communication situation and on our communication partners. A student would talk to a university professor with respect and would perhaps use formal and polite forms of language. Students among themselves would rather use **informal** and usually incorrect language, **filled up** with slang, **jargon** and sometimes **swear words**. Breaking grammatical rules and leaving out words which do not carry the main meaning is also quite typical for informal communication among the young.

6. How does direct communication differ from indirect communication?
7. What impact does the formality or informality of a situation have on the language that is used?
8. What kind of language would students probably use among themselves?

DEVELOPMENT OF HUMAN COMMUNICATION

Human communication **underwent** some historical development. In the past, humans exchanged their thoughts through sounds, facial expressions, gestures and body posture.

Later on, **spreading** information through pictures, signs and finally letters led to **significant** progress in the development of communication. In the 15th century, after *Johann Guttenberg* had invented printing, written texts were easily spread among people, which increased general education in European countries. New **inventions** of the 20th century, such as radio, television and computers, enabled mass communication among people through the spreading of information in a very short time. The amount of people using mobile phones **has rapidly increased**. It has become the quickest and the most efficient way of communication and also a part of many people's lifestyles. *Skype* and *ICQ* are modern forms of communication. They enable people to talk in real time and send and receive documents or pictures. They are an excellent source for **storing** and searching for information. They have become modern communication partners for many people. However, there is a real **threat** that people will spend more and more time in front of computers which **weakens** our abilities to socially interact and the oral form of communication. It seems that Internet communication leads mostly to the development of written communication. New inventions make communication faster and easier. Using social networks, such as Facebook or Twitter, have become a part of everyday life for millions of people. Who knows how and by what means we will communicate in the future...

9. Based on your reading, compare and contrast the way people communicated in the past and how they communicate nowadays.
10. What are the threats of using new communication technologies?

□ VOCABULARY LIST

to accompany – sprevádzať
to adjust [ə'dʒʌst] – prispôbiť sa
to apologise for (AmE: apologize) – ospravedlniť sa za
appearance – vzhľad, zovňajšok
body posture [pɒstʃə] – postoj, pozícia
Braille [breɪl] – Brailove písmo
to clarify [klærɪfaɪ] – ujasniť
communication channel – komunikačný kanál
communication skill – komunikačná zručnosť
to complain about – sťažovať sa na
to contain – obsahovať
to convert – premeniť
direct – priamy
disturbing – rušivý
to enable – umožniť
to encode – dekodovať
to enhance – posilniť, zvýšiť
facial expression [feɪʃl] – mimika
filled up (with) – byť plný niečoho
filler – vyplňujúci výraz v komunikácii
gesture [dʒestʃə] – gestikulácia, gesto

indirectly – nepriamo
intention [ɪntenʃən] – zámer
to interact – vzájomne pôsobiť
invention – vynález
jargon [dʒɑ:gən] – žargón
to mime – hranie, predvedenie niečoho pantomímou
negotiation [nɪɡəʊʃɪeɪʃən] – jednanie, rokovanie
to overuse – nadmerne používať
participant – účastník
permanent – trvalý, stály
to persuade – presvedčiť
precise [pri'saɪs] – precízny
to predict – predpovedať
prerequisite [pri:rekwɪzɪt] – nevyhnutý predpoklad
to provide [prə'vaɪd] – poskytnúť
proximity [prɒksɪmɪtɪ] – blízkosť
purpose – účel
to receive – prijímať
receiver – prijímateľ

to rely on – spoliehať sa na
to require [rɪkwaɪə] – vyžadovať
sender –odosielateľ
sign language – znaková reč
significant – významný
to spread – šíriť
subconscious [sʌbˈkɒnʃəs] – podvedomý
to support – podporovať
swear word [sweər] – nadávka
the deaf – hluchí
threat [θret] – hrozba
to undergo – podstúpiť
unless – pokiaľ ne-
value – hodnota

to vary [veəri] – líšiť sa
via [vaɪə] – prostredníctvom
visually-impaired [vɪʒuəli ɪmˈpeəd] – zrako-
vo postihnutý
to weaken – oslabiť

in accordance with – v súlade s
to communicate face to face – komunikovať
osobne
to exchange thoughts [θɔ:ts] – vymieňať si
názory
to increase rapidly – prudko sa zvýšiť
to reveal current mood – odhaliť aktuálnu
náladu

□ VOCABULARY PRACTICE

Task 1 What message do the following public signs give? Where could they be seen?



a)



b)



c)



d)



e)



f)



g)



h)

Task 2 Which things below are considered polite (P) and impolite (I) during formal conversation?

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1. to have eye contact with a partner _____ | 6. to speak quietly _____ |
| 2. to touch a partner _____ | 7. to speak a lot _____ |
| 3. to shout _____ | 8. to use polite language _____ |
| 4. to ask for repetition _____ | 9. to interrupt an on-going conversation _____ |
| 5. to bite fingernails _____ | 10. to listen to a partner _____ |

Task 3 Translate the following expressions connected with making phone calls into Slovak. If necessary, check the meanings in your dictionary.

- to look up a number in the directory _____
- to dial a number _____
- the phone is ringing _____

- 4. to pick up the receiver _____
- 5. to hang up _____
- 6. the line is engaged _____
- 7. to hold on _____
- 8. to put somebody through _____
- 9. to ask for the charges to be reversed _____
- 10. extension 567 _____
- 11. to leave a message _____
- 12. to take a message _____